INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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Published by:
mediastudies.press
414 W. Broad St.
Bethlehem, PA 18018, USA

Copy-editing: Emily Alexander

Cover design: Natascha Chtena

Landing page: mediastudies.press/iacmedia

Open Reader series - issn *(online)* 2770-940X | issn *(print)* 3143-4509

isbn 978-1-951399-33-7 *(print)* | isbn 978-1-951399-30-6 *(pdf)*

isbn 978-1-951399-32-0 *(epub)* | isbn 978-1-951399-31-3 *(html)*

doi 10.64629/3f8575cb.638fbdwo | lccn 2025938544

Edition 1 published in August 2026

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CHAPTER 39

Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women

Kenza Oumlil

Journal of Alternative & Community Media 1, no. 1 (2016): 41–55. https://doi.org/10.1386/joacm_00017_1.

Abstract

Arab-American women often find themselves represented in the mainstream media as oppressed victims in need of saving, but what sometimes gets less attention are the ways in which Arab-American women themselves are adding to the media landscape, through poetry, film and other forms. This article offers a textual analysis of artistic interventions circulated by Arab-American women in the media sphere, and supplements the analysis of the content and context of these interventions with individual interviews with the artists involved. It focuses on the poetry of Suheir Hammad and the cinematic interventions of Annemarie Jacir, which I situate as alternative media. I conceptualise alternative media as media content that challenges dominant assumptions and offers stylistic innovations for the purpose of inspiring social change. In addition, I argue that alternative media consist of transforming the existing stock of material into one's own language in order to promote social justice. The article concludes with remarks regarding the opportunities and the limitations of alternative media in effecting social transformation.

Keywords

Alternative media, Annemarie Jacir, Arab, cinema, Palestinian, poetry, Suheir Hammad, gender

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Introduction

Arab women are often represented as helpless victims in need of saving. Academic literature on the subject describes in considerable depth the workings of these reductionist and Orientalist representations of Arab and Muslim women (Abu-Lughod, 2002; Ayotte and Husain, 2005; Butler, 2004; Jiwani, 2006; Khan, 1998; Macdonald, 2006; Nayak, 2006; Parameswaran, 2006; Razack, 2008; Todd, 1998; Vivian, 1999; Yeğenoğlu, 1998). One of the key figures in this discourse is the image of the veiled woman, and particularly the core stereotype of the figure of the veiled woman as oppressed. The veil has carried symbolic and political implications since before colonial times. As Fanon (1963) demonstrates, part of the colonial mission involved controlling the dress code of local women, and more specifically unveiling Algerian women. Some Algerian women posed a threat to French colons because they carried weapons beneath their veils. Since then, the veil has continued to be a central theme in the government-led initiatives, public debates and media of many Western countries. This public discourse has been organised around a dichotomy between complete assimilation, which would involve letting go of what is perceived as problematic cultural practices, and so-called non-assimilation, encapsulated in the portrayal of the ungrateful immigrant who must not be accommodated. Such public debates of whether the veil should be tolerated have been documented in studies covering British and North American (Ayotte and Husain, 2005; Butler, 2004; Macdonald, 2006; Nayak, 2006; Todd, 1998), as well as French (Vivian, 1999) contexts. These polarisations remind us of Mamdani's (2005) description of the 'good' Muslim versus the 'bad' Muslim, whereby the 'good' Muslim's position stands on shaky ground and can easily shift to that of the 'bad' Muslim.

While one aspect of the construction of Arab female identity in mainstream media relies on the notion of an oppressed Arab womanhood that needs to be rescued; the other side of it revolves around eroticised and exoticised portrayals: these women have also been represented as objects of desire for consumption—as commodified sexual objects and belly dancers (Shaheen, 2001; Yeğenoğlu, 1998). Indeed, as Said (1994) and Karim (2000) explain, the construction of this imaginary geographical area called the Orient consisted of images of revulsion and attraction, inferiority and fascination. Yeğenoğlu (1998: 11) demonstrates that:

> the Orient as it figures in several eighteenth and nineteenth century European texts is a *fantasy* built upon sexual difference … the figure of 'veiled Oriental woman' has a particular place in these texts, not only as signifying Oriental woman as mysterious and exotic but also as signifying the Orient as feminine, always veiled, seductive, and dangerous.

Responding to the pervasive circulation of this discourse, some women have recently engaged in practices of creating their own media to alter—albeit in small ways—the flow of information. These diasporic women artists and media practitioners include Suheir Hammad, Annemarie Jacir, Maysoon Zayyid, Sundus Abdul-Hadi, Jackie Salloum and Layla Essaydi.

This article focuses particularly on the works of Palestinian-American poet Suheir Hammad and Palestinian-American filmmaker Annemarie Jacir because they have circulated long-term interventions that are attracting considerable attention. Both artists have received many awards for their work.[1] In addition, looking at these two cases enables the researcher

[1] Hammad received the Audre Lorde Writing Award, Hunter College (1995, 2000); the Morris Center for Healing Poetry Award (1996); the New York Mills Artist Residency (1998); the Van Lier Fellowship (1999); the

to take into consideration two different media: literature and cinema. I situate these works as alternative media. Based on the existing literature and on my analysis of the selected case studies, I conceptualise alternative media as media content that challenges dominant assumptions and offers stylistic innovations for the purpose of inspiring social change. Furthermore, I argue that alternative media consist of transforming the existing stock of material into one's own language in order to promote social justice. Using textual analysis and semi-structured interviews, this article focuses primarily on the ways in which the poetry of Suheir Hammad and the films of Annemarie Jacir respond to dominant representations of their identities in order to intervene in the mediasphere. In this analysis, I situate Hammad and Jacir's works as alternative because they exemplify self-representational art, serve the interests of marginalised communities and seek to challenge dominant notions about their identity—that is, they are alternative in terms of their content as well.

Alternative media

Alternative media provide an opportunity for audiences to create their own news and report on what they think is newsworthy, regardless of the editorial lines of the mainstream media (Platon and Deuze, 2003). Entertainment media enable non-professional media practitioners to present material that would differ in content and form from that presented through mainstream channels (Baltruschat, 2004; Ginsburg, 2002).

The area of alternative media studies is an emerging field of inquiry. This research interest derives from the realisation that it is not only important to understand the prevalence and influence of mainstream/mass media; it is also imperative to pay attention to other types of media that circulate in the public sphere. Among the existing types of media content, this body of literature discusses which can be defined as alternative media (Bailey, Cammaert and Carpentier, 2008; Carroll and Hackett, 2006; Hamilton, 2001; Kidd, 1999; Rodriguez, 2001). It hence explores key debates in academic and media establishments concerning the criteria used to conceptualise alternative media. For some scholars, such as Albert (1997), it is the organisation of the media institution that makes it alternative (or not); in this view, an alternative media institution (1) does not seek to maximize profit; (2) does not pursue advertisers; (3) aims to challenge traditional hierarchical relationships; and (4) is independent from state and market forces. Other scholars claim that alternative media need to be "native" to the communities they serve (Kidd, 1999) and that they also need to advocate for social change (Hamilton, 2001). This body of literature also includes an examination of the limits

2001 Emerging Artist Award, Asian/Pacific/American Studies Institute at NYU; the Tony Award for Russell Simmons Presents Def Poetry Jam on Broadway (2003); and the 2009 American Book Award. Likewise, Jacir's work received many awards and distinctions, including: World Premiere, Cannes Film Festival, Official Selection, Cinéfondation; National Finalist, Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences, Student Academy Awards; Best Short Screenplay, Nantucket Film Festival; Best Short Film, Palm Springs International Short Film Festival; Best Short Film (Emerging Narrative), IFP/New York; Silver Plaque, Chicago International Film Festival; Best Short Film, Institute Du Monde Arabe Biennial; Audience Choice Award, Polo Ralph Lauren Columbia University Festival; Special Jury Prize, Ramallah International Film Festival; Best Films of the Year list, 2003, Film Comment Magazine; and 25 New Faces of Independent Cinema, 2004, Filmmaker Magazine. More recently, Jacir was selected as one of 2010/2011's Rolex Protégées and worked under the mentorship of acclaimed Chinese director Zhang Yimou.

of alternative media in terms of effecting social transformation—see, for example, the studies of Atton (2006) and Daniels (2009) about regressive uses of alternative media.

The form of alternative media could range from a film to a video, a blog or a magazine. In his proposal of montage as a visual practice prevalent in alternative media, Hamilton (2001) articulates this idea of using the available stock of raw materials from popular culture and transforming them into something else. An interesting example of a montage that parodies Hollywood's representation of Arabs is illustrated in *Planet of the Arabs* (2005), produced by Jacqueline Salloum and inspired by Shaheen's book *Reel Bad Arabs: How Hollywood Vilifies a People*. This montage uses various shots depicting Arabs from different Hollywood movies from 1896 to 2000 to highlight the recurrent stereotypes and negative images that have consistently circulated. The montage ends with a diagnosis of these images as mass-madness and a call to turn off television sets. Personal zines could be another form of alternative media, as Poletti (2005) explains. Poletti's study focuses on modes of narrative in personal zines, located within a context of do-it-yourself (DIY) and independent cultural practices.

Clearly, new technologies have played a role in facilitating mounting challenges to dominance. Montagner (2001) describes this phenomenon as 'cyber-democracy', while Carty (2002) speaks of it as 'web resistance'. Carty examines technology and counter-hegemonic movements around issues of labour and consumption in her case study of Nike Corporation. In describing sites promoting activism on the web, Carty reflects on how the internet has served activists as an ally through such examples as the use of open-publishing newswires for grassroots coverage of protests.

Some of the main tactics of alternative media include culture jamming. Bailey, Cammaert and Carpentier (2008) situate détournement as the most relevant reference to what is described today as culture jamming. The idea of the serious parody suggests reversing, transgressing or subverting. The Situationist movement deployed the tactic of détournement as a way to fight The Spectacle through the modification of ads, news items, cartoons, and other types of cultural products. Its aim was to use manipulation in order to strip these commodities and events of their intended meanings and to subvert messages (Debord, 1994). Branwyn (1997: 14) relates jamming in alternative media to music and radio, defining it as:

> using media in new and creative ways, 'jamming' like musicians jam, making it up as they go along. Jamming also refers to the scrambling of broadcast signals, as in the interruption of a radio signal by electronic means … The whole point of alternative media is to jam the status quo with ideas and viewpoints not found in conventional media and not subject to the tidal influences of commercial sponsorship and demographics.

Other tactical interventions have involved bearing witness to political events from the position of the margins. Montagner (2001) reports on how protesters at the World Economic Forum (WEF) in Melbourne loudly chanted 'the whole world is watching' at police as they came with their own video cameras and recording equipment to document any potential abuse, and to create their own coverage of the event. Montagner also identifies other internet media groups who are similarly engaged. She concludes (2001: 16–17) that 'activists are now taking care of their own representation', and that political activists are now becoming media activists. [2]

[2] For further discussion of types of tactics deployed by alternative media practitioners, see Oumlil (2012).

Method

The works of Hammad and Jacir were selected as case studies for this analysis based on the criterion of self-representation and because they represent different forms of talking back (poetry, performance, cinema). Furthermore, I selected these case studies because they constitute long-term interventions. Jiwani (2006: 85) argues that, for change to be long-lasting, interventions must be 'consistent and persistent in challenging dominant definitions'. This article focuses on the ways in which Hammad and Jacir have responded to dominant representations of their identity in order to stage interventions in the media landscape. Drawing from postcolonial theory, critical race and gender studies, and research on Arab and Muslim representations in the media, this article uses a textual analysis and juxtaposes the main tropes of dominant discourse to the artists' responses. While all Hammad's publications—*Drops of This Story* (1996), *Born Palestinian, Born Black* (1995), *Zaatar Diva* (2005) and *Breaking Poems* (2008)—were taken into consideration for this analysis, only a few examples are used here due to space restrictions. The analysis of Jacir's cinematic interventions is based on her short films, and focuses particularly on her first feature film, *Salt of This Sea* (2008), which is also the first feature film by a Palestinian woman director. Drawing from the previously mentioned literature on alternative media, the analysis identifies the alternative media concepts and tools deployed by the selected artists to make their voices heard in the mediasphere. It is supplemented with semi- structured interviews with the artists to understand the individual motivations and the challenges the artists might have encountered in the processes of disseminating their perspectives. This analysis also relies on observations derived from Hammad's 30 March 2009 performance at Club Lambi in Montreal, which I attended in order to examine how the poet enacts her identity on stage, since it is through the performance and (re)presentation of identity that the selected artists circulate meaning.

The alternative potential of Hammad and Jacir's works

Self-representational art

The selected case studies can be described as self-representational art. Hammad and Jacir define their works as constitutive of countercultural practices. Loomba (1998) describes self-representation of the colonised as spaces for negotiation, change and resistance to colonial power. In a chapter called 'Grandma's Story', Trinh (1989: 150) addresses the need for marginalised voices to be recorded and documented. Using a specific example of a woman of colour telling a story, she says that 'even if the telling condemns her present life, what is more important is to (re-)tell the story as she thinks it should be told; in other words, to maintain the difference that allows (her) truth to live on'. According to Trinh, the importance of storytelling lies in the telling of difference. In this sense, it is not a matter of convincing the other party or winning an argument; rather, it is about preserving and circulating one's truth, one's difference, one's reality. It reflects an effort to sustain the marginalised.

The importance of producing work in one's own voice, of being one's own storyteller to recodify one's identity, has been discussed by several researchers. Rodriguez (2001) par-

ticipated in the production of a video about the work of the *grupos populares* [3] work in the Columbian Andes, and found that when the *campesinos* (or peasants) looked at themselves in the video, they transformed their self-image. She also noticed that by directing men in the process of making the video, women were empowering themselves. Rodriguez relates that the *campesinos'* ways of looking at themselves changed: the ceased being passive when they became producers of their own media images. Similarly, Juhasz (1995) reports on the vital significance of self- expression. She retraces a history of alternative media production, noting that minority producers (mostly women and people of colour) in the United States in the 1970s produced identity films for 'the promise of personal and political liberation' (1995: 40). In this light, Ginsburg (1995) speaks of the liberationist potential of indigenous and alternative media mobilised for self-determination and to resist to cultural domination. Similarly, in his analysis of the Aboriginal Peoples Television Network (APTN), Baltruschat (2004) reports that in the 1960s, Canada's First Nations started creating their own media and telling their own stories.

On the Arab-American side, Salaita (2006: 105) argues that there is an imperative to speak: 'Arabs don't speak, or aren't allowed to speak, very often in print and visual media.' Criticising how often non-Arabs moderate and mediate discussions about Arab questions in the media, he posits this situation as 'alarming' because it feeds into an environment of anti-Arab racism in which Arabs are not allowed to articulate their own sensibilities. Whereas Salaita clearly distances himself from the view that only Arabs have the right to speak about themselves, he calls for discussion of Arab issues that would include and involve community members.

When considering the significance of representations, it is important to note that concerned communities have sought to participate in deciding how they are represented. As Hall (1997) explains, representation is the way by which meaning is given to what is depicted and a key element in producing culture. He draws the connection between representation and culture by arguing that culture—a system of representations—is about shared meanings and that language (encompassing various forms of what we call today verbal and non-verbal communication) is the privileged medium for making sense of things. Thus language constructs meaning as it operates through representations.

Several scholars have called for the self-representation of marginalised communities (Baltruschat, 2004; Juhasz, 1995; Loomba, 1998; Rodriguez, 2001; Salaita, 2006; Trinh, 1989). In response to how this call has been associated with identity politics, which is supportive of the self-representation of marginalised groups, Shohat and Stam (1994) draw on Mohanty's (1991) work in order to argue that the question is not who can speak for whom, but rather how to speak together with others rather than for them. Mohanty contends that a common context of struggle is needed to build alliances/constitute commonality, rather than some essentialist understanding of identity: 'thus, it is the common context of struggle against specific exploitative structures and systems that determines our potential political alliances' (1991: 7). Hence Mohanty challenges the essentialist understanding of identity politics in favour of a politicised understanding of oppositional identity. However, such alliances are not always easy to build, as historical instances of the failure to stand in solidarity with other struggles

[3] According to Rodriguez (2001: 1), the term *grupos populares* is synonymous with 'peasants' in Latin America, and can also signify 'grassroots group'.

demonstrate: 'sadly, the record speaks for itself of many suffragists' failures to oppose slavery, of many abolitionists' failures to support women's suffrage, and of much of organized labor's failure in relation to both women workers and workers of color' (Downing, 2001: 8).

Identity politics typically is mobilised in order to achieve collective goals. Identity has always been used strategically. Spivak (2005: 477) argues that 'essentialism is always used strategically, to bypass or acknowledge difference'. Echoing the sentiment, Trinh advocates for the necessity on the part of the marginalised to maintain their existence and difference. What should not be dismissed here is the imperative of taking voice by those who have been historically silenced, a need undergirded by the necessity to circulate different and empowering narratives. These narratives are not only personal; they also reflect a position of shared marginality, and can thus be mobilised for collective political goals. With this said, the cultural producers selected for this analysis are privileged economically compared with Spivak's subaltern.[4] The hierarchy (within a marginalised bracket) creates another disjuncture in terms of who has access to speak.

Jacir has situated her work within the framework of self-representational art. In New York, with Professor Hamid Dabashi, Jacir co-founded the *Dreams of a Nation* Project, of which she was the chief curator. This project aims to provide support for Palestinian filmmaking, access to Palestinian films and a digital archive of Palestinian cinema. Furthermore, the *Dreams of a Nation* official website articulates the mission of the project within the larger framework of self-representational art, as only films made by Palestinians are included. *Dreams of a Nation* was envisioned as an intervention based on a dissatisfaction with existing portrayals of Palestinians in the dominant mediascape. The project was consciously launched to mark a rupture, to make an alternative contribution to the dominant public sphere. As Jacir (2006: 25) puts it:

> This project, of which the [2003 *Dream of Nation* film festival in New York] was a part, of presenting, archiving, and studying Palestinian cinema, in an effective manner to support the continuing struggle of Palestinians to use colors, symbols, and images to represent ourselves in the peril of the destruction of our culture … In organizing *Dreams of a Nation* we wanted to highlight and discuss the impressive feat that Palestinian filmmakers were attempting—to develop an aesthetically and socially relevant body of filmmaking just when decades of cultural development in the West Bank, Gaza, and elsewhere, were being newly threatened, and we wanted to intervene and contribute to the present rather disappointing cultural discourse on Palestine in the US by introducing the nuanced and compelling work we were seeing from Palestinian filmmakers around the world.

In a similar vein, Hammad presents the urgent need to circulate her writings when she reiterates that 'our' stories need to be told—for accuracy, for sanity. This relates to how she connects her experiences to communal ones, emphasising the sense of being part of a larger

[4] For Spivak, subalternity signifies a condition where one is removed from all social lines of mobility. In her seminal text *Can the Subaltern Speak?*, Spivak (1988) cites the example of Bhuvaneswari Bhaduri, who committed suicide in North Calcutta in 1926. The young woman had been a member of an armed struggle group for Indian independence. When the group asked her to carry out a political assassination, she killed herself. Because she was menstruating when she committed suicide, Spivak interprets this act as a 'displacing gesture' that denies the charge that she killed herself because of an illicit pregnancy (1988: 104). Spivak furthermore contends that, as a subaltern, Bhaduri rewrote the social text of sati-suicide, challenging the practice of widow burning in colonial India. In a subsequent article titled 'Scattered Speculations on the Subaltern and the Popular', she argues that 'subalternity is where social lines of mobility, being elsewhere, do not permit the formation of a recognisable basis of action' (Spivak, 2005: 476).

community marked by similar struggles and aspirations, without falling into reductionist thinking, as in her writings Hammad clearly recognises difference within identity categories. The next section addresses the communal sensibility of Jacir and Hammad's works.

Serving a community

The notion of serving a community and maintaining an indigenous voice above the surface of the water was apparent in this analysis of Jacir's work. As Jacir suggests, one of the main goals of the *Dream of a Nation* project was to create an archive of Palestinian films that academics, festival curators and other people interested in cinema could use. Jacir spoke then about the imperative of preserving a culture that is at risk of being lost:

> The other big part of the project was creating this online database to gather information and make sure it would be available so that other festivals, other academics, and other people interested in cinema could find it. We kept hearing over and over again that people were interested in these films; they heard about them or they hadn't heard about them but they couldn't find them. They didn't know how to reach the filmmakers. So it was about getting information. The main thing was to get information out there that was lacking.

In *Salt of This Sea*, Jacir depicts the lead character, Soraya, as swimming in the forbidden Palestinian sea and trying to maintain her head above the surface of the water. This sense of 'our stories' needing to be told is a shared characteristic of Jacir and Hammad's works.

The collective nature of Hammad's work has been evident since her earlier writings. A young Hammad writes in *Drops of This Story* (1996) about how the 'I' in her writings is a 'we': 'I'm still writing. So that our stories be told. For revolution. For sanity. So that we don't forget. So we always remember. I is we' (Hammad, 1996: Author's Note). In his analysis of Hammad's poem 'First Writing Since', Rothberg (2003: 153) speaks of this collective dimension: 'the poem attempts to document something of the collective dimension of the trauma and of the heterogeneity of the city'. The poem effectively speaks to multiple realities by, for example, naming some of the victims of the 9/11 attacks who belong to different ethnic groups. From the names of the victims, we know that some of them were Latino and Arab.

The collective orientation of Hammad's work is grounded in a need to take voice, which further delineates her writings as belonging to the realm of self-representational art. In her author's note to *Born Palestinian, Born Black*, Hammad (2010: ix) writes:

> Why do I write? 'Cause I have to. 'Cause my voice, in all its dialects, has been silenced too long. 'Cause women are still abused as naturally as breath. Peoples are still without land. Slavery exists, hunger persists and mothers cry. My mother cries. Those are reasons enough, but there are so many more.

Thus Hammad writes because her voice has been silenced, and here she refers to how the perspectives of marginalised communities have been erased. She also writes because she needs to speak out against the injustices they endure (the marginalised communities exemplified here are women, the colonised, the enslaved and the poor). The poet often employs the word 'community' and the notion of collectivity. During the interview, she states, 'I come from all these different communities who complement each other.' Hammad hence views her standpoint as situated in multiple communities. Since she started writing, her poetry has been infused with a notion of coming together in respect and of building bridges of solidarity between different positions and locations of marginality. But beyond being located as self-

representational art that serves the interests of particular communities, what aspects of the works of Hammad and Jacir belong to the realm of alternative media content?

Alternative content

Drawing from the previously mentioned literature on alternative media, I argue that one of the key characteristics of alternative media is the type of content it circulates, which needs to be different from that presented in the mainstream. It also needs to articulate a social justice agenda. The two selected case studies both present the characteristics of such content. Hammad's poetry responds to a large repertoire of Palestinian, Arab and Muslim representations that attempt to naturalise, normalise and fix these images and dominant tropes in order to provide alternative framings. Said (1994) examines the large body of work that constructs the East as backward and inferior, and labels it Orientalist discourse. Shaheen (2001) denounces how Palestinians are constructed as animals in Hollywood films, and are quite simply denied their status of human beings. Hammad attempts to make these stereotypes uninhabitable. Hall (1997) contends that we may reverse stereotypes if we make them uninhabitable by interrogating them and asking, among other questions, where the images come from, who is silenced in the production of the images and what is missing (what is not there is just as important as what is represented).

Hammad's publications include a memoir and three collections of poems. *Drops of This Story*, a memoir that chronicles her life as a young Palestinian female growing up in Brooklyn, was written at the age of 19 and subsequently published four years later in 1996. She has also published three collections of poems: *Born Palestinian, Born Black* (1995), *Zaatar Diva* (2005) and *Breaking Poems* (2008). Overall, her work responds to harmful portrayals by negating their very foundation while also offering an alternative language. Her work has a live dimension, as she performs her poetry on stage across the world. I attended one of her performances in Montreal on 30 March 2009. The Simone de Beauvoir Institute at Concordia University was the primary organiser of the event, which was held at Club Lambi on Saint Laurent Boulevard in Montreal. That evening, Hammad opened her performance with her poem 'not your erotic/not your exotic'. The significance of this opening is situated in its double negation: the poem simultaneously deals with gender and race as it deconstructs the assumptions of gendered and exoticised portrayals. Here, Hammad demonstrates an awareness of dominant constructions of Arab women's identity and chooses to challenge this dominant discourse by the use of a double negation, clearly stating that she does not see herself in the image of the sexualised and objectified other. The poem goes on to mention several of the core stereotypes used to denigrate women, and alludes to the international nature of the objectification of women, as not only 'harem girl[s]' are targeted, but also 'geisha doll[s]' and others, thereby building bridges between the different struggles women experience throughout the world.

Hammad's poetry presents contemporary counter-narratives of race and gender. Whereas it gravitates between impulses to translate these 'profane' bodies and reminders that they are closed to translation, Hammad's writings break stereotypes and expose what was made unreal in an effort to rewrite experiences of otherness and marginality. Here I refer to Butler's *(2004)* notion of the 'derealisation of the other' that, when applied to existing stereotypes about Arabs and Muslims, frames them as beyond discursive dehumanisation. For Butler, 'derealisation' implies that these bodies are neither alive nor dead. Violence inflicted on unreal bodies can-

not be conceived as causing injury or death because their lives have already been annulled. Butler adds that these lives become ungrievable.

Hammad connects various forms of oppression based on difference and describes them as situated in a 'system based on money' (quoted in 'letter to anthony (critical resistance)', published in 2005 in Zaatar Diva). The author's note in the first edition of *Born Palestinian, Born Black* (1996: ix) opens the volume with June Jordan's poem 'Moving Towards Home': 'I was born a Black woman / and now / I am become a Palestinian'. Furthermore, in 'letter to anthony (critical resistance)', Hammad writes, 'and these people / bronx bomber they imagine a world / where money can't be made off the hurt / of the young the poor the colored the / sexualized the different' (2005: 67).

Hammad's poetry also unsettles dominant discourses by negating pejorative linguistic constructions and offering alternative portrayals to these hegemonic representations. Her writings often identify the dominant categories constructing subordinated identities (Palestinian, Muslim, Arab, woman) in order to unmask the workings of linguistic domination. She sums up these central tropes as operating under a dehumanising framework imposed by 'those who've denied our humanity eternally' (1996: 7). Simultaneously, she creates categories to talk back (hooks, 1989), by using both literal and subtle language. For example, the poem *Exotic* (Hammad, 1996) contains a literal double negation that brings together race and gender: 'don't wanna be / your erotic / not your exotic.' Therefore, she refuses eroticisation and exoticisation of herself. In her memoir, Hammad (1996: 75) relates an experience of being looked down upon as being unintelligent, a characteristic that is often associated with working-class immigrants who are portrayed as uneducated, backward, uncivilised and pre-modern:

> SWAM the ocean to be written. I wrote this out in English class in high school, while my teacher kept her eye on me, 'cause she was sure I was gonna cheat. She was so busy copping me, wouldn't notice the other students scheming right under her nose. These drops dripped off the Shakespeare I had to re-read so new teachers would believe that I understood it.

This quote addresses institutionalised racism and discrimination due to difference in schools. It challenges the notion of the classroom environment as separate from the real world, together with any notion that presupposes that instructors encourage an environment of equal learning for all. The quote also speaks of the immensity of writing that remains to be done when Hammad says, 'swam the ocean to be written', referring to how voices like hers have historically been silenced, and how other/dominant discourses have appropriated her identity and her story to tell it in a way that exerts their dominance. The word 'drops' subsequently alludes to how her memoir, which is entitled *Drops of This Story*, can only provide a few drops [of water] to fill in the gap—a gap so large that it resembles an ocean.

An example of proposing an alternative portrayal to the dominant notion of Muslim masculinity as dangerous, threatening and violent can be found in 'First Writing Since'. Hammad associates Muslim masculinity with being 'gentle': 'both my brothers, gentle Muslim men'. This statement negates the central trope of the violent Muslim man. Like all statements that talk back (hooks, 1989), it is inevitably positioned *vis-à-vis* a dominant logic that has been disseminated widely through mainstream media.

In an early postcolonial text that deconstructs the dominant tropes of colonial discourse, Césaire (1972) identifies and denounces the framing of the colonised in animalistic terms.

The mainstream media have often constructed Palestinians as less human and more animal like (Salaita, 2002; Shaheen, 2001). In his analysis of representations of Arabs in Hollywood films, Shaheen (2001) describes how Palestinians and Arabs are described as animals, pigs, dogs, rats and savages. Hammad (2005: 66–67) brings this central colonial trope to the surface through a sarcastic reiteration in her poem 'letter to anthony (critical resistance)' when she says:

> the world pointed and Palestinians do not exist Palestinians are roaches Palestinians are two legged dogs and Israel built jails and weapons and a history based on the absence of a people Israel made itself holy and chosen and my existence a crime.

In this case, Hammad uses sarcasm to express the opposite of what 'the world' says—'the world' here points to how overwhelming and powerful dominant discourses about Palestinians are; it highlights the repetition of these hurtful images that depict Palestinians as animals. Hammad does not use capitalisation throughout, further emphasising that language is a construction—that is, something that is not real. Immediately after denaturalising (by revealing) the colonial trope of Palestinians as animals, Hammad follows with the real implications of these words: 'Israel built jails and weapons'. At the same time that she denounces the irony of representing Palestinians as animals, Hammad reveals the erasure of the existence of Palestinians—'the absence of a people'—thereby showing in one stanza the binary and paradox of this representation. On one hand, Palestinians do not exist, yet on the other hand, they are depicted as animals. She ends this stanza by depicting how they are criminalised (another central trope of the same discourse).

Annemarie Jacir's work also presents alternatives to mainstream discourses. While *Salt of This Sea* is her first feature film, Jacir has been working in independent cinema since the early 1990s. She has written, directed and produced several short films and videos since 1994, including *A Post Oslo History* (1998), *Sayyad al-satilayt/The Satellite Shooters* (2001), *Filastin tantazir/Palestine is Waiting* (2002), and *Kanhun 'ashrun mustahil/Like Twenty Impossibles* (2003), which also premiered at Cannes and is a winner of several awards. The symbolism of the titles, *Like Twenty Impossibles*, tellingly reveals the impossible conditions of doing this type of work and producing such films.

In response to Palestinians' forced invisibility, this film affirms their existence in an attempt to rupture efforts to erase history. Said (2006) contends that Palestinian cinema stands in relationship with and/or in opposition to two main elements: a forced position of invisibility and a wide-reaching repertoire of dominant representations. He argues (2006: 3):

> Palestinian cinema must be understood in this context. That is to say, Palestinians stand against invisibility, which is the fate they have resisted since the beginning; and on the other hand, they stand against the stereotype in the media: the masked Arab, the *kufiyya*, the stone-throwing Palestinian—a visual identity associated with terrorism and violence.

Said (2006: 2) also describes the Zionist effort to render the existence of Palestinians invisible, quoting an early rallying phrase of Zionism: 'We are a people without a land going to a land without a people? It pronounced the emptiness of the land and the non-existence of a people.'

Salt of This Sea rewrites history from the point of view of the 'weak'. De Certeau (1984) defines a tactic as the 'art of the weak', which introduces clever tricks into the foundations of power. For de Certeau, while a tactic is time-based, a strategy (of the state, for example) is space-based. A number of scholars mention rewriting history as an intervention (Ginsberg,

2002; Shohat and Stam, 1997; Stam and Spence, 1985). Ginsberg (2002) additionally discusses the use of footage as a means to provide visual evidence of indigenous existence, which serves to counteract the erasure of indigenous stories and histories from dominant national narratives. *Salt of This Sea* opens with this type of historical footage [5] —which originates from the military archives in Jerusalem—showing soon-to-be Palestinian refugees being forced to leave from the port of Jaffa in 1948. [6]

The plot revolves around the retrieval of Soraya's grandfather's savings from the bank by the three main characters (Soraya, Emad, and Marwan), which is not defined as theft in the film as his bank account was frozen when he was exiled in 1948. After they recuperate Soraya's grandfather's savings, they decide to travel to the sea. They first go to Jerusalem, then to the port city of Jaffa. In order to cross over to Israel, they need to disguise themselves. In this scene, they each must pass for another body in order to have access— specifically, they must pass as Jews to enter Israel. Humour is also used in the same scene via carnivalesque tactics of play. For example, Emad wears a t-shirt that reads, 'America don't worry'. This offers spectators a temporary and therapeutic escape from oppressive circumstances.

When the trio arrives at the beach, their presence bothers the Israeli sunbathers; they are clearly unwelcome. We hear and see a helicopter flying over the scene, which symbolises the apparatus of high surveillance that polices the circulation of bodies. Foucault (1977) exemplifies such surveillance in the figure of the panopticon. Visually represented by the watchtower within the prison, for Foucault the panopticon is a structure of surveillance that disciplines subjects to behave in docile ways because they know that they are being watched. In this figure, the few see the many. Thus one tower guard can oversee the movements of the entire prison population.

The beach scene in *Salt of This Sea* visually depicts the Palestinian characters' presence as being uncomfortably noticeable. While they are delighted to have made it there, they are subjected to the dominant gaze when Israeli sunbathers start to look their way upon hearing them speak in Arabic. The characters' ambiguous relationship with this particular sea is introduced. Jacir tells us that, on one hand, every Palestinian wants to go to the *forbidden* sea: we see Marwan transported into a realm of joy; we see the sun kissing Emad's face in scenes that depict the characters' happiness when they finally reach their destination. On the other hand, as Jacir notes, this sea has also taken refugees away from their homes.

Salt of This Sea attempts to undo efforts to erase history; it tries to affirm Palestinian existence and document their passage through that land. The film places a determined heroine at the centre of its narrative in opposition to more common representations, including the infamous figure of the oppressed veiled female in need of saving. It also attempts to reverse the understanding of criminality in the Middle East. Although emerging from a position of marginality, this film achieved considerable popularity among specific interpretive communities, for whom it has attempted to alleviate certain socio-political stresses and provide mental nourishment through tactics of playfulness, as demonstrated by the characters in several scenes. Such scenes include the planned robbery of the bank; the crossing into Jerusalem and then travelling on to Jaffa; and the journey on the road, which highlights their life on the run and emphasises the notion of escaping from a burdensome reality. However, as

[5] In Like Twenty Impossibles, Jacir also relies on the use of documentary footage.

[6] This information is derived from Mullenneaux's (2010) interview with Jacir.

Entman (2003) and Said (1994) argue, the circulation of a few divergent stories is insufficient to effect any sort of significant social change. These stories could end up washed away in the sea of dominant discourses.

Conclusions

Ample research shows that Arab women have been represented in limited and negative ways. The racialised construction of Arab women's identity is linked to the historical stereotyping of other marginalised groups. Wilson, Gutierrez and Chao (2003) demonstrate that different ethnic groups have been represented as inferior at various moments in history, according to the political mood of the time. Other research demonstrates the pervasiveness of the dominant media because of the concentration of media ownership and the exportation of the US media system to the rest of the world (McChesney, 2004). It is because of this media conundrum that alternative media provide a means, a set of tools and a different view of the role of media in society. I have here sought to reflect on the scholarly debate regarding the definition of alternative media and the criteria used to evaluate their potential.

This article examined the artistic interventions of Palestinian-American poet Suheir Hammad and Palestinian-American filmmaker Annemarie Jacir. The analysis revealed that their interventions present unique insights into the processes of creating and circulating alternative media. Both artists directly and eloquently call for the self-representation of Palestinians. Situated as self-representational art, their works speak from the location of community on behalf of the interests of marginalised groups. Just as importantly, the ideas they have circulated present alternatives to the hegemonic contents of mainstream media.

I have conceptualised alternative media as media content that challenges dominant assumptions and offers stylistic innovations for the purpose of promoting social justice. Based on the selected case studies, the contribution I offer to the study of alternative media highlights the importance of three main criteria for conceptualising the value of alternative media: using self-representation, serving a particular community and presenting alternative content.

This call for self-representation is not new; other scholars have made the point previously (Baltruschat, 2004; Ginsburg, 1995; Juhasz, 1995; Rodriguez, 2001; Salaita, 2006). While we have been discussing this for a number of years, Arab-American women are just entering the field of media as producers of content and contributors to public discourse. The scarcity of Arab-American voices has implications that can be linked directly to discourses of racism (Salaita, 2006). It hence becomes imperative to study the ways in which Arab voices in general, and Arab women's voices in particular, get to participate in the public sphere.

The second criterion of serving the interests of a particular community, and of society at large, is also presented in the literature (Hamilton, 1999; Kidd, 1999). Both Hammad and Jacir provide alternative messages and perspectives in their works, by rewriting narratives of otherness, rectifying erasures of history and advocating for social justice via the use of collective memory and communal language. In sum, they have placed their works within broader socio-political struggles.

The third criterion of presenting alternative content needs particular emphasis. I have argued here for the imperative of refraining from conceptualising alternative media solely based on its organisational structure, the funding it receives, its independence from state and

market forces, and other factors. I propose to also take into account the messages communicated. Taking into consideration the question of content would involve asking the following questions: is the proposed discourse alternative? Does it offer counter-narratives to discourses of domination? Does it invent a new language to inspire social change? It must be reiterated here that how marginalised groups say things is connected to how they see them, and that seeing them in a certain way does not depend on some innate ability unique to marginalised groups. But if those who have been historically silenced continue to be denied the opportunity to speak, then we as audiences will continue to be blind to their perspectives.

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Author Information

Email: Oumlil@aui.ma